

PRIMATES

The order to which humans belong, primates have a large brain relative to their size and forward-facing eyes which give them 3-D vision.

With the exception of a few species, including humans, primates are restricted to tropical and subtropical regions of the Americas, Africa, and Asia. They range in size from a mouse lemur, weighing 30 g (1 oz), to a gorilla weighing up to 200 kg (440 lb).

Primates rely more on vision than on smell. Many are arboreal and have characteristics such as stereoscopic vision, allowing good judgement of distance for jumping between trees; opposable thumbs and a prehensile tail for grasping branches; long legs for leaping; and long arms for swinging. Some primates have specialized diets, but many other species are omnivorous.

MAJOR GROUPS

Primates are divided into two suborders. The Strepsirrhini includes the mostly nocturnal lemurs, lorises, galagos, and their relatives. These species have a better developed sense of smell

than other primates. The Haplorrhini includes the New and Old World monkeys and the apes, many of which are diurnal, and so more reliant on vision than the Strepsirrhini.

SOCIAL PATTERNS

Most primates are highly social, living in small family groups, single-male harems, or large mixed-sex troops. Many species are characterized by high levels of male competition for females. Sexual selection favouring the largest or most dominant males has led to sexual dimorphism – differences between males and females in body size or features such as canine teeth. The different sexes may also be differently coloured, a form of dimorphism known as sexual dichromatism.

Most New World monkeys are monogamous, with both parents sharing responsibility for raising their young. Old World monkeys tend to live in groups dominated by related females, and the males take little or no part in parental duties. Primates are generally slow to mature fully and slow to reproduce, but they are relatively long-lived. The larger apes have a potential lifespan of up to 45 years in the wild, and longer in captivity.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	MAMMALIA
ORDER	PRIMATES
FAMILIES	16
SPECIES	506

DEBATE

PRIMATE HOTSPOTS

Today scientists list more species of primates than a decade ago – most the result of subspecies (geographical variants) being recognized as new species. In the Amazon basin populations of monkeys separated by rivers and mountain ranges can differ in subtle ways – such as in the structure of their chromosomes. Some scientists believe that these monkeys diverged when their forest habitats became isolated due to geological activity many thousands of years ago. Such forests may contain many species isolated in this way and are a particular focus of conservation groups aiming to protect biodiversity.

GALAGOS

Native to sub-Saharan Africa, the members of the family Galagidae inhabit a wide range of woodland and forest habitats, including scrub and wooded savanna. They have longer hind legs than forelegs, which help them to take large leaps between trees in forests. These primates often wash their hands and feet with urine, which may help to improve their grip and leave scent-trails. All are nocturnal.



SILVERY GREATER GALAGO
Otolemur montei

This species has the same range as the brown greater galago but prefers denser vegetation. Despite its name, melanistic (black) forms are common.

BROWN GREATER GALAGO
Otolemur crassicaudatus

One of the largest galagos, this primate lives in a variety of forests in southern Africa. This omnivore uses its comb-like teeth to scrape gum from trees.

26–40 cm
10–16 in